

HARMONIC RHYTHM VS. PHRASING

FROM DIGGING DEEPER JAZZ VIDEO #42

A lot of players get messed up by the Harmonic Rhythm of songs, the flow of the chord changes, where the chords happen, and how long they last. Simply put, Harmonic Rhythm is the rhythm of the harmony - where in the measure do the chords fall? Many times, the chords of a given song might go against the "typical phrasing rules," like we discussed in Digging Deeper Video #41, "Phrasing Is Sexy."

Example #1 is the bridge to the song "Have You Met Miss Jones." The harmony, the ii-V progressions, would be grouped like this, circled in red. This is how we would think about the chords working together. As you can see, the circles are not at all in keeping with the four measure phrases. The harmony is actually very much against the four measure phrase.

#1

Example #1 shows a 4-measure phrase in 4/4 time. The top staff (treble clef) contains the following chords: B^bMAJ⁷ (measures 1-2), A^bMI⁷ (measure 3), D^b7 (measure 4), G^bMAJ⁷ (measures 5-6), EMI⁷ (measure 7), and A⁷ (measure 8). The bottom staff (treble clef) contains: DMAJ⁷ (measures 1-2), A^bMI⁷ (measure 3), D^b7 (measure 4), G^bMAJ⁷ (measures 5-6), GMI⁷ (measure 7), and C⁷ (measure 8). Red circles group the ii-V progressions: (B^bMAJ⁷, A^bMI⁷), (D^b7, G^bMAJ⁷), and (EMI⁷, A⁷) in the top staff; and (DMAJ⁷, A^bMI⁷), (D^b7, G^bMAJ⁷), and (GMI⁷, C⁷) in the bottom staff. The notation uses slashes for notes.

In Example #1, the harmony has us playing AGAINST what typical four measure phrasing would dictate. The chords have us playing AGAINST the form and the phrasing, and guess what? A lot of players will get lost in the changes of this tune, get lost in the form, or at best be playing some lopsided phrases that just sound weird and don't flow. Sound familiar?

Experiment with breaking the harmonic flow, but staying with the good four measure phrasing, as in Example #2 below. Most of us will have better luck this way. You'll sound more natural, and your ideas will be more coherent. THEN, once you have nailed this, (ie. you can do this 20 times in a row without mesing up), go back to Example #1 above, and begin to mix and vary your phrasing. But, get VERY SOLID with Example #2 first!

#2

Example #2 shows a 4-measure phrase in 4/4 time. The top staff (treble clef) contains the following chords: B^bMAJ⁷ (measures 1-2), A^bMI⁷ (measure 3), D^b7 (measure 4), G^bMAJ⁷ (measures 5-6), EMI⁷ (measure 7), and A⁷ (measure 8). The bottom staff (treble clef) contains: DMAJ⁷ (measures 1-2), A^bMI⁷ (measure 3), D^b7 (measure 4), G^bMAJ⁷ (measures 5-6), GMI⁷ (measure 7), and C⁷ (measure 8). Red circles group the ii-V progressions: (B^bMAJ⁷, A^bMI⁷) and (D^b7, G^bMAJ⁷) in the top staff; and (DMAJ⁷, A^bMI⁷) and (D^b7, G^bMAJ⁷) in the bottom staff. The notation uses slashes for notes. The word "REST!!" is written in large, bold, black letters over the final two measures of both staves.